



“Those deaths must have been the most dramatic in the world’s history. They fell – a cone of blazing wreckage – watched by eight million of their enemies.”

MURIEL DAYRELL-BROWNING
EYEWITNESS TO THE DESTRUCTION OF
ZEPPELIN SL 11 OVER LONDON, 1916

ZEPPELINS AND BOMBERS

**GIANT AIRPLANES AND AIRSHIPS
BROUGHT THE TERROR OF WAR
TO THE CITIES OF EUROPE**

EVEN BEFORE World War I, the airship was fixed in the popular imagination as a symbol of terror. In his 1908 book *The War in the Air*, H.G. Wells had described an airship raid on New York leaving “ruins and blazing conflagrations and heaped and scattered dead.” It was a vision that appealed to some military commanders. Captain Peter Strasser, head of the German navy’s airship fleet, believed that Britain could be “overcome by means of airships... through increasingly extensive destruction of cities, factory complexes, dockyards...”

The Germans had no monopoly on the intent to bomb enemy cities and factories. But they did have the lead in airship technology, and in 1914 airships were the only aircraft capable of carrying a significant bombload far enough to hit strategic targets.



AIRSHIP COMMANDER

Peter Strasser, Commander of the German Navy Zeppelin Fleet during World War I, was an ambitious officer who made the Zeppelin an effective weapon of war. He died when the L 70 was shot down over England.

were shot down in the first month of the war. They were also distressingly accident-prone, especially in bad weather.

Stealthy raiders

However, an answer to the airship’s vulnerability in combat was sought in stealth. On a moonless night, despite their bulk, Zeppelins could evade detection and pursuit. Out of necessity they became night raiders. The German army and navy used airships to bomb a variety of strategic targets under cover of darkness, including Paris and other French cities. But their most prized target was Britain, and above all London. In those bitter, hate-filled days of war, German schoolchildren learned to sing: “Zeppelin, fly! Fly to England! England will burn in fire!”



SHADOW OVER THE WESTERN FRONT

The Zeppelin Staaken R.IV, of which the above is a model, flew on the Western Front in 1917–18. This six-engine monster had a wingspan of 138ft 6in (42.2m) and, when fully loaded, weighed over 14 tons (13 tonnes).

However, at this stage they were not capable of fulfilling apocalyptic visions of mass destruction. Whether metal-framed Zeppelins or plywood-framed Schütte-Lanzes, German airships revealed serious drawbacks early in the war. The army found that they could not survive over the battlefield. Traveling at under 50mph (80kph), they presented large, tempting targets for gunners on the ground; four army airships